
WHAT

Transdisciplinarity: embracing collaboration, tackling challenges, and cultivating equality

Transdisciplinary education has various definitions, but they all agree on one thing: the nature of collaboration. Academic, educational, and non-educational partners join forces in learning, working, and researching.

The various participants are connected through a central problem or challenge – a second characteristic. Transdisciplinarity is about engagement with complex societal and sustainability issues for which there is no clear-cut solution or method.

A third characteristic of transdisciplinarity is the form of involvement. In transdisciplinary teams, all partners work together based on equality. You cannot concretely delineate the relationships, as everyone must learn together to develop new knowledge and innovative ideas. Therefore, some authors suggest that “there are no transdisciplinary experts, only transdisciplinary practitioners.”

These characteristics lead to challenges, especially from an educational perspective. TRAIL provides guidelines and insights to help you face these challenges.

Inter- or Transdisciplinary: Common Confusions

Literature and experts emphasize that the concept of transdisciplinarity is not always clearly defined (Klein, 2017). The distinction between trans- and interdisciplinary collaboration is often unclear. Both approaches aim for the integration of various types of knowledge. Transdisciplinarity distinguishes itself by involving non-academic stakeholders as equal participants in the collaboration. Therefore, transdisciplinarity encompasses a greater diversity of perspectives and types of knowledge. As complexity increases, so do the challenges and opportunities for learning and new knowledge development.